Country Profile: Bolivia

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholicism
- Official language: Spanish and Indigenous languages
- Official religion: None, since 2009
- Core group: None, since 2009, Whites/Mestizos (1945–2008)

Historical Background

Administered as a Spanish colony by the Audiencia y Cancillería Real de La Plata, Provincia de los Charcas, Bolivia was established as an independent republic in 1825 after more than a decade of struggle for independence that followed the Sucre rebellion. In the course of the 19th and early 20th centuries, Bolivia was involved in several territorial wars with its neighbors, resulting in significant territorial losses before 1945. After 1945, Bolivia experienced phases of both authoritarian and more democratic governance. The presidency of Evo Morales (2006–2019), the first head of state of explicit indigenous background, was associated with increased constitutional recognition of the rights of Bolivia's indigenous population, but also democratic backsliding.

Groups

- **Whites / Mestizos** are the descendants of European settlers that arrived during the colonial era. As a distinct racialized group, they make up around 41% of the population.[1] They speak Spanish,[2] the *de facto* language of the state. The clear majority of this group adheres to Roman Catholicism, the plurality religion and, until 2009, official faith of the Bolivian state,[3] with only small communities following Protestant or other Christian beliefs.[4] Until the constitutional reforms in 2009, Whites / Mestizos formed the core group of Bolivia.

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[1] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
2 Ethnologue, 2025.
3 ARDA, 2025.
4 Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017; Gill, 1990.

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- **Quechua**, comprising approximately 31% of the Bolivian population,[5] form an indigenous racialized group that has historically inhabited the country's highlands, although, over time, many Quechua have migrated to urban centers.[6] They speak variants of the Quechua macrolanguage, particularly North Bolivian Quechua and South Bolivian Quechua.[7] Around half of the members of the group have adopted the Roman Catholic faith, while another fifth practices Protestantism, and slightly more than a 10th adheres to other forms of Christianity.[8] Quechua have maintained an active self-determination movement since 1952, the year of the first widespread uprising against the Bolivian government and the mining companies.[9]
- **Aymara** are an indigenous racialized group inhabiting the Bolivian highlands. They amount to around one-quarter of the Bolivian population.[10] Central Aymara is the language of their shared identity, although Spanish is increasingly used today.[11] About half of the Aymara are Roman Catholic, with the rest following different Christian denominations, including Protestantism.[12] Similar to Quechua, Aymara have been involved in the struggle for more Indigenous autonomy since 1952.[13]
- **Lowland Indigenous Peoples** are a racialized nested group of Indigenous peoples, comprising, among other groups, **Chiquitano**, **Ese Ejja** and **Guaraní**. A small minority in Bolivia, Lowland Indigenous Peoples account for roughly 4% of the total population.[14] The group is linguistically diverse, with the languages of the three largest subgroups—Chiquitano, Ese Ejja, and Eastern Bolivian Guaraní, respectively —being the most widely used.[15] As Lowland Indigenous Peoples have been less exposed to Catholic conversion than highland communities, animist beliefs and different Christian denominations are widespread among them: more than half of Chiquitanos continue to practice animism, another third Roman

[5] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[6] Minority Rights Group, 2024.
[7] Ethnologue, 2025.
[8] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[9] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[10] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[11] Ethnologue, 2025.
[12] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[13] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[14] CEPAL, 2005; Birnir et al., 2018; Minority Rights Group, 2025.
[15] Ethnologue, 2025.

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Catholicism, and a small fraction follows Protestantism. Among the Ese Ejja, animism and Protestantism form two larger communities of roughly equal size, followed by a smaller Roman Catholic group. Finally, animism and Protestantism are also practiced by more than a third of Guaraní, while just above a fifth adheres to the Roman Catholic faith.[16] Since 1982, Lowland Indigenous Peoples have actively demanded autonomy via the CIDOB (Indigenous Confederation of the East, Chaco and Amazon of Bolivia).[17]

State Profile

Official Language

Before 2009, Spanish served as the *de facto* national language, although it lacked official constitutional recognition. The 2009 Constitution proclaimed Spanish and 36 indigenous languages as official languages of the state, naming all of them in Article 5: "The official languages of the State are Spanish and all the languages of the rural native Indigenous nations and peoples."[18]

Official Religion

Before the 2009 Constitution, Roman Catholicism held the status of state religion. For example, Article 3 of the 1947 Constitution reads: "The State recognizes and upholds the Catholic, Apostolic and Roman religion, guaranteeing the public exercise of any other religion."[19] The 2009 Constitution removed these stipulations.

Education Policies

The Bolivian education system relies predominantly on public schools which are, amid funding shortages and a lack of resources, supplemented by private, often religious, institutions. *De jure*, primary education is free and compulsory for children aged 6 to 13, although mandatory schooling remains difficult to enforce, particularly in rural areas. This is followed by four years of optional secondary education in preparation for university studies.[20]

[16] Joshua Project, 2025.
[17] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[18] Constitution of Bolivia, 2009.
[19] Constitution of Bolivia, 1947.
[20] McFarren and Arnade, 2025.

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Affirmative action initially took the form of admissions quotas for Indigenous students, determined by the respective universities themselves. In 2010, the government of Evo Morales established three universities specifically for Indigenous students—the Universidad Aymara "Tupak Katari", the Universidad Quechua "Casimiro Huanca", and the Universidad Guaraní y de Pueblos de Tierras Bajas "Apiaguaiki Tüpa"—taking action to increase access to higher education for the country's Indigenous population.[21]

Language Education Policies

From 1955 to 1994, Bolivia's educational language policy was centered on assimilation into **Spanish**, with indigenous languages such as **Quechua**, **Aymara**, **Chiquitano**, **Ese Ejja**, and **Guarani** taught optionally during the early years of primary school solely to facilitate Spanish acquisition. This approach was codified in Article 115 of the 1955 Bolivian Education Code, which explicitly described Indigenous languages as vehicles for national linguistic integration (Código de la Educación Boliviana 1955).[22]

A major shift occurred in 1994 with the passage of the Educational Reform Law (Ley Nº 1565), which formally introduced intercultural bilingual education (EIB), recognizing the sociocultural diversity of Bolivia and extending bilingual instruction in primary schools first to Quechua and Aymara, and in 2000 to Guaraní speakers and Amazonian languages such as Chiquitano and Ese Ejja.[23] These policies also extended the use of these languages in secondary education as language classes.

The policy expanded further with the 2010 Avelino Siñani-Elizardo Pérez Education Law (Ley 070), which institutionalized EIB at the secondary level and called for the creation of Indigenous Language and Culture Institutes to support language standardization and development.[24]

Religious Education Policies

Until 2006, Bolivian public schools imparted Catholicism in mandatory classes. However, even before the 2009 Constitution abrogated the official status of the religion, the 2006 Education Act mandated secular teaching with respect to all religions, ending

[21] Vaca, 2009; Pérez, 2020.
[22] Gustafson, 2017, 37.
[23] Howard, 2009, 584–585; Paichadze and Álvarez, 2006.
[24] Gustafson, 2017, 43.

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denominational religious education in the state's school system.[25] Private schools were free to teach any religion.

Constitutions and Laws

Since 1945, six constitutions or significantly amended constitutions, adopted in 1944/45, 1947, 1961, 1967, 1994, and 2009, have governed the state organization in Bolivia.

Social tensions in the early 20th century shaped Bolivia's constitutional history. The first constitution included in the NBP database was adopted by the populist military government of Colonel Gualberto Villarroel López. After his assassination in 1946, reforms introduced by the regime were largely rolled back, although without altering key principles of the governance of ethnic diversity. The constitutions of 1945 and 1947 recognized the presence of Indigenous groups, for instance, in Art. 165 and Art. 168 respectively: "the State recognizes and guarantees the legal existence of Indigenous communities."[26] While Art. 3 of both constitutions recognized universal religious rights, the same articles declared Catholicism the official religion of the state. An official language is not stipulated.

Subsequent constitutional texts—adopted in 1961, institutionalizing the principles of the 1952 Revolution such as universal suffrage, and in 1967, although the latter was suspended (*de facto* but not *de jure)* for a decade after the coup by General Alfredo Ovando Candia in 1969—upheld previous definitions of the relation between state and church in their respective Art. 3. They also refrained from establishing an official language but, in contrast to previous texts, no longer recognized Indigenous groups. This was reversed via constitutional amendment in 1994, with Art. 171 of the amended constitution recognizing Indigenous rights once again.

Major changes were brought about by the 2009 constitution, in declaring Boliva a "multinational" state, promulgated by President Ivo Morales after popular approval by referendum. The constitution explicitly references the multitude of identities present in Bolivia, stating in Art. 3 that "[t]he Bolivian nation is made up of all Bolivian men and women, the Indigenous native peasant nations and peoples, and the intercultural and Afro-Bolivian communities that together constitute the Bolivian people."[27] As per Art. 4,

[25] Rosso, 2011.
[26] Constitution of Bolivia, 1947.
[27] Constitution of Bolivia, 2009.

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the state is "independent of religion." Art. 5 recognizes Spanish but also all Indigenous languages, leaving the state with as many as 37 official languages.

Citizenship Laws

The Bolivian nationality law follows the principle of *ius soli*, enshrined in the constitutional framework. As held in Art. 39 of the 1945 and 1947 constitutions, Art. 35 of the 1961 constitution, Art. 36 of the 1967 constitution, and Art. 36 of the 2009 constitution, those born in the territory of the state are considered nationals.

The 1961 Constitution introduced special provisions for Spaniards and Latin Americans, allowing them to acquire Bolivian nationality without renouncing their original citizenship if reciprocal agreements existed. These privileges were maintained in subsequent constitutions.

National Anthem(s)

The Bolivian national anthem was adopted in 1845 and is now available in Spanish and some Indigenous languages. The anthem features references to national ancestors and historical heroic deeds, such as fighting bravely in wars, as well as martyrdom. Military references are used in descriptions of warfare. Finally, the national territory is described as "tierra inocente y hermosa" [an innocent and beautiful land].

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